



Man of steel: Russell's biggest threat came from the less fancied Red Bull of four-time world champion Max Verstappen (in pic). PICS: REUTERS

couple more laps and the result could have been different. But the Dutch driver would also have had to contend with a rapid Antonelli, who finished just three tenths behind him at the chequered flag.

"It was a very good race for us. In hindsight we could have done the undercut to jump ahead and I think I had the degradation edge over George but overall I am pleased with P2. We did some good racing and I didn't expect us to be that strong against the Mercedes," Verstappen said after the race.

The race in Austria also came as a rude shock to those expecting a closer title fight until the end of the year. After the high of Hamilton's first win in red last time out, and with Ferrari starting second and third on the grid, the team was once again primed to hunt down Russell. But the script played out very differently.

The Prancing Horse struggled to keep up with the pace of its competitors, including the slow-starting McLarens, and continued to fall backwards throughout the race. Hamilton finished fifth behind Oscar Piastri and Leclerc eighth behind Isack Hadjar and Lando Norris.

"Looking back, we were perhaps too focused on Mercedes today. We pushed hard in the opening laps and then reacted too aggressively with the strategy, trying to stay with them when, realistically, that wasn't our race," team principal Fred Vasseur said.

The Maranello-based team's upgraded engine has helped it shorten the gap to Mercedes, but there is still a lot to be done before it can mount a serious title challenge.



MotoGP



Ai Ogura (**in pics**) won the Grand Prix of the Netherlands at Assen to end a 22-year wait for a Japanese rider to stand on the top step of the podium, with the last such victory coming through Makoto Tamada in his home race. The Trackhouse MotoGP team enjoyed a 1-2 finish after Raul Fernandez finished runner-up.

Marco Bezzecchi crashed out early on his Aprilia and conceded the championship lead to teammate Jorge Martin, who finished third. Two-time world champion Francesco Bagnaia, who recently announced that he will leave Ducati at the end of the season, retired from fourth place with just 10 laps remaining.

